ORIGINAL EXPERIENCE · UNDERGRADUATE RESEARCH

The First Research Questions: Nutrition, Oncology and the NCD Project

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> **I won a research award for a project I could never publish.**

BACKGROUND: In second year, I went department by department, ward by ward, trying to understand oncology and nutrition and what was being done.

METHODS: With Institutional Research Committee and Ethics Committee approval, we drafted a protocol based on the WHO STEPS 1 and 2 programme to assess risk factors for non-communicable diseases on campus.

RESULTS: We prepared a report and presented it at national forums and undergraduate conferences. The project earned me the KUHS UG Research Award.

CONCLUSIONS: We could never get around to publishing it. Far too much data.

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BACKGROUND

While in second year, I started going department by department, ward by ward, trying to understand oncology and nutrition and what was being done.

OBSERVATION

Why were the diet books always empty?

I tried to understand if there was a nutritionist on board, why the diet books were always filled up with renal-related diets, and the diet was always just milk and eggs.

REVIEW OF LITERATURE

So I started reading. I started going into journals. I started looking up random terms in oncology, trying to understand what a review of literature was.

So who was assessing whether the people in Malabar were getting higher cancer rates due to this very rate of consumption?

NARROWING IT DOWN

My dear professor and HOD, Dr. Asma Rahim, and Dr. Ashik Refeek told me to narrow it down.

We started making it into nutritional assessment of patients, and then we modified it to cancer patients.

I took this very project to Dr. Sanudev. He told me we could do it, and then I let go of that project for a while.

METHODS

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It was an initiative by the then College Union to run a health camp.

A lot of data would come in, a lot of tests would be done. Why waste it if we could assess the health metrics and risk factors of all the students on campus?

METHODS

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We drafted a protocol based on the WHO STEPS 1 and 2 programme, where we assess the risk factors for NCDs.

With Institutional Research Committee approval and Ethics Committee approval.

RESULTS

It took another one and a half years for me to get into the data, understand it and learn how to process it using SPSS and Excel formulas.

We eventually managed to prepare a report and present it at national forums and undergraduate conferences.

LIMITATIONS

> **To this day, I believe we spread ourselves too thin.**

Too much data. Far too much data. Unsegmented, without the necessary tools or the team to understand the data, structure it properly or even publish it.

CONCLUSIONS

The project eventually earned me the KUHS UG Research Award.

But to my dismay, I was never able to publish it.

#	PROJECT	OUTPUT	STATUS
1	**WHO STEPS 1 & 2 risk-factor survey (NCD)**	Presented at national forums and UG conferences	NOT PUBLISHED
2	**Nutritional assessment of cancer patients**	Indian J Med Paediatr Oncol, Mar 2026 (2nd author)	PUBLISHED
3	**Metastatic solitary fibrous tumour, parapharyngeal region**	Indian J Med Paediatr Oncol, Apr 2025 (6th author)	PUBLISHED
4	**Juvenile justice and recidivism (elective)**	Report and forums; not pushed for publication	NOT PUBLISHED
5	**Obesity-driven cardiac mortality, US adults 15 to 44**	JAHA, Oct 2026 (4th author)	PUBLISHED
6	**Retrosternal goitre case series**	Ongoing	IN PROGRESS

That is something that will always bother me. And it is something that I will owe the people who made it possible, and the campus, for a while.

NEXT

Next: the electives. Juvenile justice, oncology and nutrition.

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